

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

course so far. It was within just six months that she emerged as the "brightest kid" of her batch and was admitted to a Cambridge IGCSE school. "The school has taken the onus of ensuring she keeps up with the learning," says Dr Lagdhir Desai, administrative officer, Municipal School Board, Ahmedabad.

But it wasn't that easy to convince Anita's father to let her attend school.

"We have to counsel the parents regularly. The kids, on the other hand, are very excited and sincere"

Lagdhir Desai, *Administrative Officer, Municipal School Board, Ahmedabad*

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **Depending on a child's age and capability, the Signal School teachers impart basic education to them for 10 months**
- **The children are then admitted to the nearest government or grant-in-aid school**
- **Around 415 children have been covered in three batches since the project's launch in March 2022**

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"We have to counsel the parents regularly," says Desai. "The children, on the other hand, are very excited and sincere." Teachers also take the kids for regular haircuts and get them books, uniforms and other educational materials. Even after getting them enrolled in a regular school, the officials keep track of the child's progress to ensure they don't drop out.

Desai says Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, who flagged off the project in 2022, continues to oversee it and seeks regular updates. But the project is the brainchild of Justice Arvind Kumar, former chief justice of the Gujarat High Court who is now a Supreme Court judge. The GSLSA continues to closely monitor the progress of every child. The project was initially sanctioned a budget of Rs 3 crore, but a bigger allocation is on the cards, say those in the know. Besides, the government also plans to replicate it in other cities of Gujarat, to bring a ray of sunshine to many more young lives. ■